Lesson 8 — The Line We Share

Part 4 of 12: Grammar — the first and second conditional

Level: B1 (eighth step)

About 50 minutes · this part carries a sheet

Come back to: the future with will and going to

Lesson 6 taught the two futures: going to for a decision already made, will for a decision made as you speak, and for an opinion. Two lines to remind you:

SHE IS GOING TO APPLY IN THE SPRING.	IT IS DECIDED
I think she will get in.	it is an opinion

New this time: after when, as soon as, before, after and until, English uses the present simple for future time.

This is the rule that the whole of today's grammar rests on, so it comes first:

I will send it when the power comes on. ✓
I will send it when the power will come on. ✗
She will apply again after she finishes the course. ✓
Wait until the latency drops, and then upload it. ✓

The future is already marked once, in the main clause, by will. English does not mark it twice. The time clause looks present and means future.

TIME CLAUSE — PRESENT SIMPLE	MAIN CLAUSE — *WILL*
When the class starts,	she will turn the video off.
As soon as the uplink comes back,	the lesson will continue.
Before she sends anything large,	she will tell the others.
Until the storm passes,	nobody will climb to the roof.

Quick practice. Put the verb in the right form.

1. I will call you when the power _____ (come) on.
2. She will apply again after she _____ (finish) the exam.
3. We will wait until the latency _____ (drop).
4. As soon as the slides _____ (load), the class _____ (begin).

A conditional sentence has two halves: the if-clause, which sets a condition, and the main clause, which says what follows. The order does not matter — If the uplink fails, nothing works and Nothing works if the uplink fails are the same sentence. Put a comma in only when the if-clause comes first.

Today there are two of them, and the difference between them is not time. It is how likely the speaker thinks it is.

3.1 The first conditional: real, and possible

if + present simple , will + verb

Use it for a real possibility in the future — something that may well happen:

IF-CLAUSE	MAIN CLAUSE
If the class fails on Monday,	she will read the slides.
If she is accepted,	she will go for one semester.
If it comes down in the storm,	they will put it up again.

Notice that the if-clause follows exactly the rule you have just revised: it is present in form and future in meaning. If the uplink will fail is wrong for the same reason when the power will come on is wrong.

You can replace will with another modal when the meaning needs it:

> If the line is slow, the video may stop.
> If you need to send something large, you should say so first.
> If the latency drops, we can start.

3.2 The second conditional: unreal, or unlikely

if + past simple , would + verb

Use it for something that is not true now, or that you think will not happen. The past tense here is not past time — it is distance from reality:

IF-CLAUSE	MAIN CLAUSE
If she had a reliable fifty megabits,	she would stop planning around it.
If I lived nearer the college,	I would walk.
If they knew which hour it was,	they would plan the week properly.

She does not have fifty megabits. That is the whole point of the sentence. The past tense is what tells you so.

With be, use were for every person in careful written English:

> If I were you, I would apply.
> If the line were faster, she would not need Sunday night.

(If I was you is common in speech and is not wrong there. Write were.)

would becomes could for ability and might for a weaker guess: If she had the money, she could buy a better antenna.

3.3 First or second? The test — and it is not about time

	FIRST	SECOND
The speaker thinks	it may well happen	it is not true, or will not happen
If-clause	present simple	past simple
Main clause	will	would
Example	If she is accepted, she will go.	If she had a faster line, she would stop planning.

Both sentences above are about the future. The tense does not tell you when; it tells you how real the speaker thinks it is. Applying is real — she has sent the form. Fifty megabits is not.

3.4 unless = if … not

unless replaces an if-clause that is negative, and then the clause itself turns positive:

WITH *IF … NOT*	WITH *UNLESS*
If the uplink does not come back, the class is over.	Unless the uplink comes back, the class is over.
If you do not tell them first, they will be annoyed.	Unless you tell them first, they will be annoyed.

Two negatives is the mistake to watch for: unless the uplink does not come back says the opposite of what you mean.

3.5 Negative and question

	FIRST	SECOND
Negative	If it does not load, she will not wait.	If she did not have the recordings, she would not cope.
Question	What will you do if it fails?	What would you do if you had a faster line?

3.6 Grammar practice

A. First conditional. Put both verbs in the right form:

1. If the uplink _____ (fail), the class _____ (be) over.
2. If she _____ (be) accepted, she _____ (go) for one semester.
3. If two people _____ (ignore) the rule, everyone _____ (know).
4. She _____ (send) her questions as messages if the lesson _____ (not happen).

B. Second conditional. Put both verbs in the right form:

1. If she _____ (have) a faster line, she _____ (stop) planning around it.
2. If I _____ (be) you, I _____ (apply) this year.

3. If they _____ (know) when the power was coming, they _____ (not need) a plan.
4. What _____ you _____ (do) if the tower _____ (come) down tonight?

C. First or second? Choose, and say why:

1. If it rains tomorrow, we (will stay / would stay) inside.
2. If I (am / were) rich, I (will buy / would buy) everyone a line.
3. If the slides (load / loaded) in time, the class (will start / would start) at eight.
4. If she (does not get / did not get) the place, she (will apply / would apply) again.

D. Rewrite with unless:

1. If the uplink does not come back, the class is over.
2. If you do not tell them first, they will be annoyed.

E. Come back to — when, before, until:

1. I will upload it when the latency _____ (drop).
2. She will not apply until she _____ (pass) the exam.
3. Before she _____ (send) anything large, she will tell the others.